

## HAIL HIM or NAIL HIM!

**TEXT:** Matthew 21:1-9 (NKJV) *“Now when they drew near Jerusalem, and came to Bethphage, at the Mount of Olives, then Jesus sent two disciples, 2 saying to them, ‘Go into the village opposite you, and immediately you will find a donkey tied, and a colt with her. Loose them and bring them to Me. 3 And if anyone says anything to you, you shall say, ‘The Lord has need of them,’ and immediately he will send them.” 4 All this was done that it might be fulfilled which was spoken by the prophet, saying: 5 “Tell the daughter of Zion, ‘Behold, your King is coming to you, Lowly, and sitting on a donkey, A colt, the foal of a donkey.’” 6 So the disciples went and did as Jesus commanded them. 7 They brought the donkey and the colt, laid their clothes on them, and set Him on them. 8 And a very great multitude spread their clothes on the road; others cut down*

*branches from the trees and spread them on the road. 9 Then the multitudes who went before and those who followed cried out, saying: “Hosanna to the Son of David! ‘Blessed is He who comes in the name of the Lord!’ Hosanna in the highest!”*

**INTRO:** In our text Jesus is making His triumphal entry into the city of Jerusalem. It is a remarkable event recorded by all four Gospels. It is quite unlike anything else recorded about Jesus in the New Testament.

Prior to this time Jesus:

- Had been withdrawing himself as much as possible from public notice...
- Had voluntarily gone into the wilderness...
- Was deflecting rather than courting attention...
- Was avoiding anything that hinted of public display...

Listen to what the Bible says.

- Matthew 12 - *"He did not cry, nor strive, nor cause his voice to be heard in the streets."*
- Matthew 16 – *"He charged His disciples that they should 'tell no man that he was Jesus the Christ.'"*
- In Mark 5 - When He raised the daughter of Jairus - *"He straightly charged them that no man should know of it."*
- Mark 9 - When Jesus came down from the mount of transfiguration, He gave orders to His disciples that *"they should tell no man what things they had seen till the Son of man was risen from the dead."*
- John 6 - After feeding the 5,000 - *"When Jesus therefore perceived that they (the multitude) would come and take him by force, to make him a king, he departed again into a mountain himself alone."*

- When his half-brothers urged him to disclose himself to the world, He answered, "*My time is not yet come.*"

But here we see Jesus making a public entry into Jerusalem. There is a huge crowd of people who have come out to welcome Jesus. And the Pharisees say, "*Behold the world is gone after him.*" (John 12:19)

Would it surprise you to know that there were two parades that day? One was a military parade whose Grand Marshall was Pilate riding a Rolls Royce chariot, pulled by thoroughbred horses. The other was a rag tag group of people whose hero was riding a donkey!

- One (Pilate) rode in from the west – The other (Jesus) rode in from the east...
- One (Pilate) would be honored – The other (Jesus) would be dishonored...
- One (Pilate) would be celebrated – The other (Jesus) would be falsely accused...

- One (Pilate) would be consulted – The other (Jesus) would be assaulted...
- One (Pilate) would enjoy the pleasures of this worlds system – The other (Jesus) would experience the bitterness of death...
- One (Pilate) would live on in infamy the other (Jesus) would live on in eternity...

Make no mistake about it – there were two crowds on the Eastern side of the city descending the Mount of Olives toward the Eastern Gate – There was the Hail Him crowd and the Nail Him crowd! These two crowds are in:

- Every city...
- Every country...
- Every family...
- Every church...
- Every gathering...

Both crowds are here today...

## **I. THE HAIL HIM CROWD...**

It was Sunday and Jesus approached Jerusalem riding on the foal of a donkey. (It was Passover and this city whose normal population was in the thousands now is host to hundreds of thousands)

Jesus and His followers descended the eastern slope of the Mount of Olives. (Symbolic of Messiah approaching the Eastern gate)

Because of all the miracles Jesus had performed - particularly because of the raising of Lazarus from the dead, people were beginning to think of Jesus as a conqueror. And so they grabbed palm branches, which are always the sign of a conqueror and began to throw them into the oncoming path of Jesus and His donkey.

It is very important to note that they were not hailing Him as a spiritual Messiah, but as a political savior - a political deliverer. (Big difference)

The very idea of Passover was the ideal of being freed from the boot of Roman oppression. Because Passover celebrated God delivering the children of Israel from Egypt, the people surrounding Jesus that day were stating that they were ready for another deliverer who would drive the Roman empire out of business in Israel.

They wanted somebody to lead them in a liberation fight against the Romans. And when the people heard what Jesus had done with Lazarus, they thought, *"This is the man - And this is our chance!"*

The crowd cried, ***"Hosanna."*** The word ***"Hosanna"*** means *"save now."* It is not so much a praise as it is a prayer. They were

saying, *"Oh, Jesus, great Conqueror, King of Israel, save US now."*

They were not considering spiritual salvation they wanted a political revolution! The people in our text may have been praying but they were crying ***"hosanna!"*** They were pleading, *"Save US now! Save US now!"*

They wanted to be saved in the physical sense but Jesus was about to do one better and offer them salvation in the spiritual sense. But it wasn't going to be enough for this crowd! They would go from Hail Him, to Nail Him in less than a week.

The Bible says that they cried, ***"Hosanna to the Son of David: Blessed is he who comes in the name of the Lord; Hosanna in the highest!"*** These people appear to be praising Him. We should praise Him all of the time:

- We can praise God by the way we live...
- We can praise God by the way we pray...
- We can praise God by the way we give...
- We can praise God by the way we witness...
- We can praise God by the way we work...
- We can praise God by the way we sing....

We must understand that when we Hail (Praise) Him, not everyone will be happy about it!

As the people were voicing their praise, some of the Pharisees called to Jesus from the crowd and said, "***Teacher, rebuke your disciples.***" (Don't let the dissenters be the deciders!)

Luke 19:40? He said, ***"I tell you that, if these should hold their peace, the stones would immediately cry out."***

Listen, the Lord is going to get praise whether He gets it from us or not. The Bible says, ***"The mountains and the hills shall break forth into singing...and all the trees of the field shall clap their hands."*** I do not want a rock, tree, mountain or an inanimate object to take my place praising Him so excuse me while I take a 20 second praise break!

The Bible says, ***"Let everything that hath breath praise the Lord – Praise ye the Lord."***

Praising people are part of the Hail Him crowd – Those who are nervous about praising Him are a part of the Nail Him crowd! (This was true then and it is true now!)

If someone's praise makes you nervous then you need to step up your game! Stop Nailing Him and start Hailing Him!

## **II. THE NAIL HIM CROWD...**

There was a festering problem in Jerusalem on this Passover. We would like to think the problem was on the western side of the city, entrenched in the crowd that surrounded Pilate and the religious system. To be sure it was there but it was also on the Eastern side of the city with the fickle people who were throwing palm branches and clothes in the streets in front of Jesus and His donkey!

These people appear to be engaged in worship but they are far more interested in a political solution rather than a spiritual renewal!

Jesus knew their hearts.

Now they were shouting, "***Hail him, hail him, hail him!***" But Jesus knew that in five days they would be shouting, "***Nail him, nail him, nail him!***"

In the parallel passage in Luke, we are told that when Jesus looked over the city "***He wept over it.***" (Luke 19:41) He wept because He knew that behind the façade of their praise and worship they would be a part of the Nail Him crowd in a few short day's.

## **CONCLUSION:**

If Jesus were here this morning, He would weep over the spiritual condition of many of us. We have all worshipped this morning – We have definitely been a part of the Hail Him crowd – But some of us already have plans to be a part of the Nail Him crowd by committing intentional sin over the next few day's:

- Some plan to lie their way out of a situation...

- Some plan to cheat a business partner...
- Some plan to steal their way into prosperity...
- Some plan to cheat on their spouse to satisfy a carnal desire...
- Some plan to continue walking in unforgiveness...
- Some plan to gossip and backbite...

They were hypocrites. They were shouting "***crown him***" one day and "***crucify him***" the next. While we are astounded by their actions, we do much the same by the way we live, and act!

Are we going to be a part of the Hail Him or Nail Him crowd?